# Article 1: "Strategic Significance of Pakistan: Challenges and Way Forward"

## 🗺️ Part 1: The Foundational Explanation

This article argues that Pakistan's **geo-strategic location** is a double-edged sword[1]. While it has advantages, it has imposed more security challenges than benefits[2].

**Key Advantages:**

- Pakistan is located at the "doorway" to the oil-rich **Middle East** and the resource-rich **Central Asian Republics**[3].
- This gives it the potential to become a major **"transit economy"** (a passageway for trade)[4].

Key Challenges:

The article identifies three main fronts for Pakistan's challenges:

1. **The Eastern Front (India):**
    a. Pakistan faces a large, "hostile neighbour," **India**, with which it has a history of wars and unresolved issues, most notably **Kashmir**[5555].
    b. The article states that the current Modi-led government has "aggressively pursued" a policy to malign and **isolate Pakistan** at regional and global levels[6].
2. **The Western Front (Afghanistan):**
    a. Decades of instability in Afghanistan are a primary security threat[7].
    b. This challenge is broken into three phases:
        i. Being a frontline state during the **Soviet occupation (1979-89)**[8].
        ii. Participation in the **Global War on Terror (GWOT)** after 9/11[9].
        iii. Dealing with the fallout of the **US withdrawal** (post-August 2021)[10].
3. **The Internal Front:**
    a. The country also suffers from internal challenges like **political instability**, illiteracy, and **religious/ethnic diversity** that hamper its path to prosperity[11].

**The Cost of Alliances:**

- The article argues that Pakistan's decision to join US-led alliances (against the Soviets and in the GWOT) was not really a choice[1212].
- Pakistan had to **"pay a huge price"** for these alliances, resulting in the loss of over **70,000 lives** and massive costs to its economy[13131313].

## 🧐 Part 2: Deeper Critical & Professional Analysis

1. The "Two-Front" Security Dilemma

The article's core argument is that Pakistan is caught in a two-front security nightmare.

- **On the East:** It faces a conventional military threat from India, which escalated during the **Pulwama/Balakot crisis in 2019** [14]and the **revocation of Article 370** in Kashmir[15].
- **On the West:** The problem is not just Afghan instability, but India's alleged role there. The article accuses India's intelligence agency (RAW) of taking advantage of the post-9/11 situation to **"destabilise and marginalise Pakistan"**[16]. It claims India used Afghan soil to support anti-Pakistan elements[17]. This turns the Afghan border into a second hostile front, actively supported by Pakistan's eastern rival.

2. Afghanistan: A "Strategic Compulsion"

The analysis stresses that peace in Afghanistan is not just a preference for Pakistan, it is a "strategic compulsion"18.

- **The "Spill-over Effect":** The Afghan wars had a devastating "spill-over effect" on Pakistan. This includes planting the seeds of **"religious intolerance"** and a pervasive **"gun culture"** that didn't exist before[19].
- **The Birth of the TTP:** The article states that a direct result of the GWOT was the emergence of the **Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP)**, a militant group that has targeted thousands of civilians and military personnel *inside* Pakistan[20].
- **US Drone Strikes:** The GWOT also led to US drone strikes on Pakistani soil, which caused **"extensive collateral damage"**[21212121]. The article cites that only **3% of drone casualties were high-value targets**, meaning the vast majority were civilians, which the UN termed a violation of human rights[22].

3. The Shift in "Great Power" Politics

The article portrays Pakistan's relationship with the US as purely "transactional" and situational23.

- **1980s (Cold War):** The US needed Pakistan to counter the Soviet Union[24].
- **2001 (GWOT):** The US needed Pakistan to fight Al-Qaeda in Afghanistan[25252525].
- **Present Day:** The US's main strategic interest has shifted to **countering China**[26]. To achieve this, the US has built strategic ties with **India**, renaming the region the "Indo-Pacific" to placate them[27].
- This shift, combined with the US's constant **"do more"** mantra [28], has pushed Pakistan to lean more heavily towards **China** (e.g., CPEC and the One Belt One Road initiative)[29292929].

4. The Way Forward: From Geo-Politics to Geo-Economics

The article concludes that Pakistan must change its entire strategic focus.

- It must move away from **"Geo-Politics"** (being a pawn in global power games) and focus on **"Geo-Economics"** (using its location for economic uplift and trade)[30].
- This requires a "pragmatic foreign policy" that balances relationships with both the **US and China** [31]and prioritizes internal political stability and economic development[32].

# Article 2: "Pakistan's Foreign Policy: Initial Perspectives and Stages"

## 📜 Part 1: The Foundational Explanation

This article explains *why* Pakistan's foreign policy took the shape it did right after its independence in 1947. The central argument is that Pakistan's policy was one of **necessity**, not of choice[3333].

Two Main "Determinants" (Driving Forces):

The article states that all of Pakistan's early decisions were forced by two immediate problems:

1. **National Security (The "Indian Factor"):** This was the **"main objective and determinant"** of its foreign policy[34343434].

    a. This was based on India's **"stubborn antagonism"** [35]and the belief among Indian leaders that Pakistan was not viable and would soon collapse and rejoin India[36].
    b. This created a **"fear composite"** in Pakistan, which was reinforced by India's military actions in taking over the princely states of **Junagadh, Hyderabad, and Kashmir**[37373737].
2. **Financial Factor (Economic Survival):**
    a. At its birth, Pakistan was an **"economically and financially, a weak country"**[38].
    b. The article accuses India of trying to **"strangulate Pakistan"** from the start by creating disputes over the division of rightful assets, such as cash balances, defense stores, and canal water[39].

**The Result: Choosing a Side in the Cold War**

- These two existential threats (security and economic collapse) **"compelled"** Pakistan's leaders to seek foreign aid[40].
- The article concludes that Pakistan had **"no choice"** but to join the **Capitalist (US) bloc** to get the military and economic aid it desperately needed for its survival against India[41414141].

The "Ideal" Guiding Principles:

While necessity dictated its actions, Pakistan's "ideal" foreign policy principles were:

- **Quaid-e-Azam's Vision:** "friendliness and goodwill to-wards all the nations of the world"[42].
- **Ideological Factor:** As an ideological state, Pakistan aimed to build a **"brotherly relationship"** with all Muslim countries[43].
- **Support for Self-Determination:** To support all suppressed nations, especially **Kashmir and Palestine**[44444444].
- **Cooperation with the UNO:** To uphold the UN charter[45].

## 🧐 Part 2: Deeper Critical & Professional Analysis

1. A "Security-Driven" State

The article's critical analysis is that Pakistan's foreign policy has always been "reactive," not independent46.

- The **"Indian Factor"** was the primary lens through which all other foreign relations were viewed[47].
- Building alliances with the US, seeking unity with Muslim nations, and going to the UN were all *tools* to achieve the one, core national interest: **ensuring its security and survival against India**[48484848].

2. The Conflict: Idealism vs. Realism

The article highlights a fundamental clash in Pakistan's policy from day one.

- **The Idealism:** Quaid-e-Azam's initial vision was one of **"neutrality"** and "non-alignment" in the Cold War ("friendship to all, malice to none")[49].
- **The Realism:** This ideal quickly collided with the harsh *reality* of Pakistan's security and financial weakness. The article cites the famous "Lord Palmerston" principle: states have no permanent friends or enemies, only permanent **"national interests"**[50505050].
- Pakistan's number one national interest was *survival*. Therefore, the **Realism** of aligning with the US for guns and money quickly overrode the **Idealism** of neutrality.

3. Who Actually Makes Pakistan's Foreign Policy? The "Troika"

This is the article's most important analysis. It argues that foreign policy is not made by the Foreign Ministry 51or the Parliament 52 alone.

- The real decisions are made by the **"Administrative Troika"**: The President, the Prime Minister, and the **Chief of Army Staff (COAS)**[53].
- **Why the COAS?** Because Pakistan's foreign policy is fundamentally a *national security* policy, the **armed forces have always held a "major position"** and decisive role in its formulation[54].
- The article gives the historical example of **General Ayub Khan** who, as Commander-in-Chief in the 1950s, played an "important role" in pushing Pakistan to join US-led defense pacts[55].

4. Public Opinion vs. State Policy: The Suez Canal Example

The article gives a powerful example of the gap between public sentiment and state policy.

- **Suez Canal Crisis (1956):** When Egypt nationalized the canal, the Pakistani **public was "immensely in favor of Egypt"** on religious and anti-colonial grounds[56].

- **Pakistan's Official Policy:** The government's official policy, however, was aligned with the **"interests of the West"** (its allies, the US and UK)[57].
- This incident clearly shows that the state's strategic, "realist" decisions (based on its alliances) were completely separate from the public's ideological and emotional feelings.